
TRAVERSING SPACES

Exploring Fugitivity Through Research-Creation

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A NAME AT THE MEMORIAL

SFU

“This is why I traverse spaces — to connect the dots as if it were a puzzle that no one asked me to solve.”

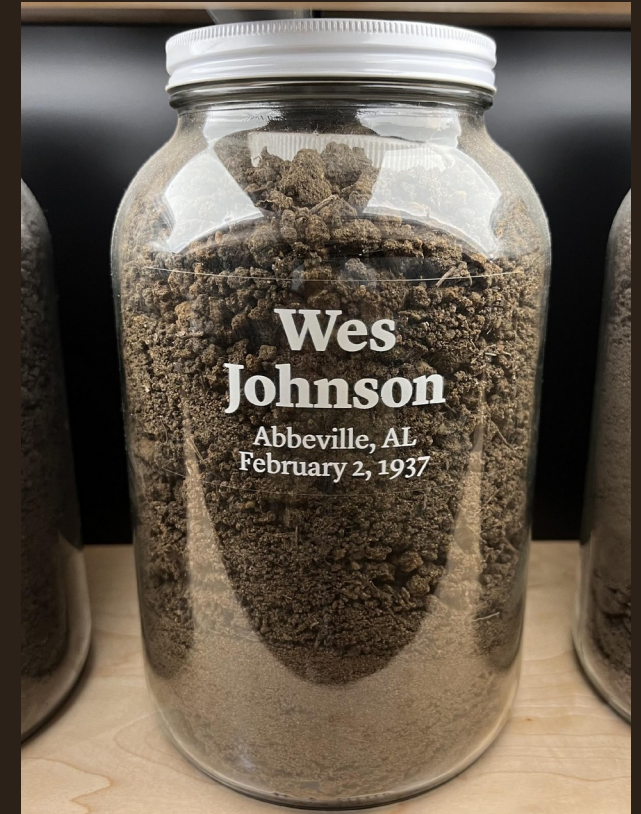


PHOTO CREDIT: EJI REMEMBRANCE PROJECT & TYLAR CAMPBELL

OUTLINE

1. The problem
2. Key terms
3. The method: the podcast
4. Inception: the Memorial
5. Three sites
6. Oral-telling as return
7. Where it stands

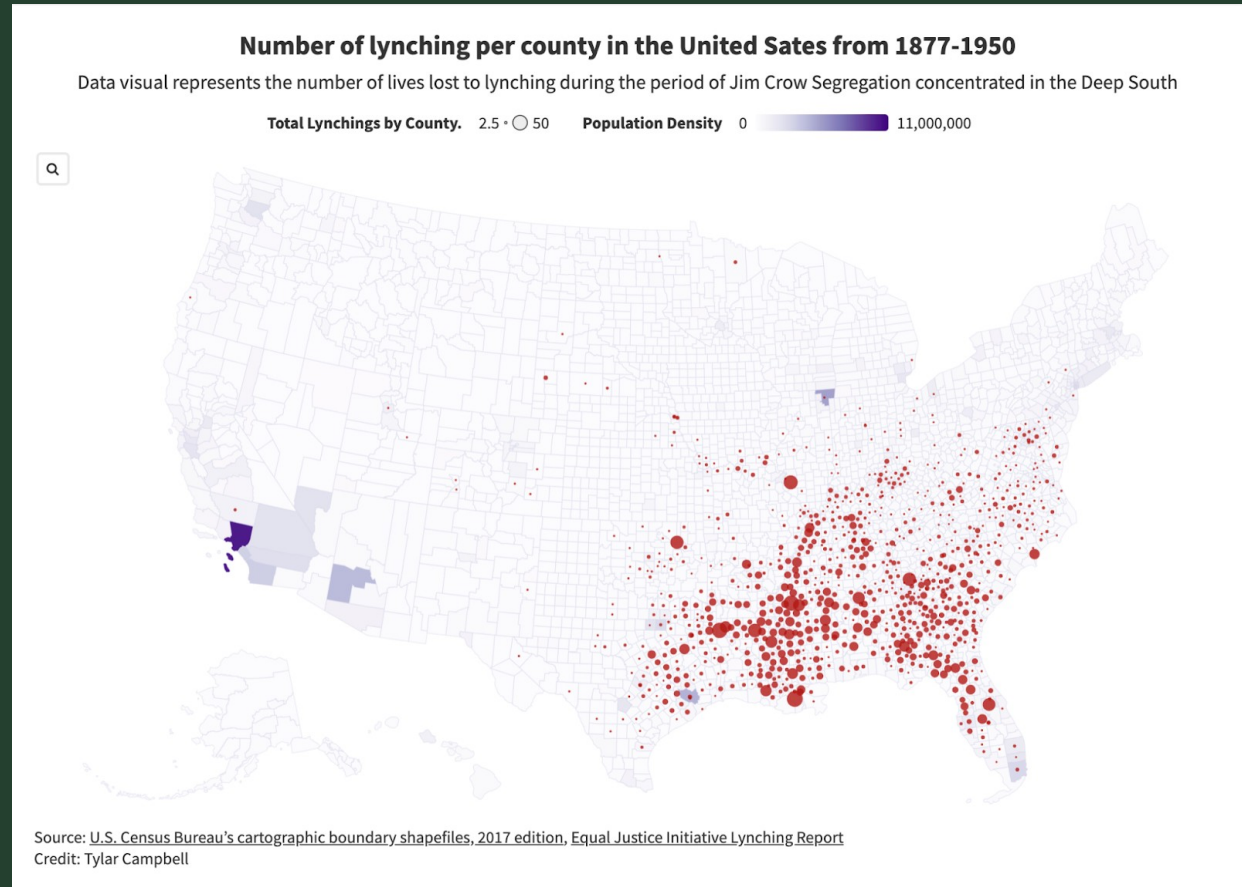
THE ARCHIVE TRACKED PEOPLE WHO ESCAPED — AND ERASED WHERE THEY WENT.

IN MY WORDS:

“...a different type of anthropology, one that centers voices often neglected, unheard, and erased.”

— Tylar Campbell

HARTMAN, “VENUS IN TWO ACTS” (SMALL AXE, 2008) · TROUILLOT, SILENCING THE PAST (1995)



FOUR KEY TERMS

Four ideas you will hear throughout this talk, in plain words.

Fugitive anthropology

Research that follows how Black people expose unjust rule and plan their way to freedom.

Research-creation

Making things (sound, 360° tours, 3D scans) is part of how the research is done.

The podcast as method

Listening and recording on site, then returning the episode to the community: the fieldwork itself.

Oral-telling as return

Passing this information down: remembrance of family members through storytelling.

Traversing Spaces

ARTICLE DOIS CHECKED · CROSSREF

The archive was built to track people who escaped and to erase where they went. This research follows those routes back through place, sound, and image, and returns them to descendants instead of extracting from them.

1 · THE PROBLEM

Silenced archives

Who gets remembered, and who the record was built to erase.

Saidiya Hartman

Scenes of Subjection · "Venus in Two Acts" (Small Axe, 2008) · Lose Your Mother

Michel-Rolph Trouillot

Silencing the Past

Best & Hartman 2005

"Fugitive Justice"

Archives as resource and problem

Route evidence that also encodes silencing

2 · THE STANCE

Fugitivity & Black place

Flight and refusal as a way of knowing, and land as memory.

Berry et al. 2017

"Toward a Fugitive Anthropology"

Harney & Moten 2013

The Undercommons

Katherine McKittrick

Demonic Grounds · a Black sense of place

Dunnavant 2020 · Nelson 2019

Fugitive geographies · the Canadian refuge archive

3 · THE METHOD

Multimodal research-creation

Making as inquiry, shown in "Deep Roots, Bama Soil" (2024).

The podcast as method

Listening and recording on site, returned to community

Campbell 2024

Museum Anthropology · narrative multimodal anthropology

Collins, Durrington & Gill 2017

"Multimodality: An Invitation"

Chapman & Sawchuk 2012

"Research-Creation"

Takaragawa et al. 2019

"Bad Habitus" · co-authored by Smith & Hennessy (SIAT)

Smith & Hennessy 2020

"Anarchival Materiality" · SIAT lineage

Kinship & care

Wesley Johnson · Held, The Ethics of Care

4 · THE PRACTICE

Place, sound, image

Fieldwork made into works people can enter.

Oral-telling as return

Episodes to descendant communities

Photogrammetry

Hotel Lincoln · Congo Square

Black Locust

SVA / Lemelson fellowship

Acoustic Avatar (VR)

George Moses Horton · with Cecil Brown & Steve DiPaola

360 / VR / drone

Corridor documentation

5 · THE RETURN

A community-held map

Where the routes live, held with descendants.

Traversing Spaces site

Geolocated map · traversnspaces.com

Trace

Record-linking where a historian approves each link

Time-enabled splats

Web layer after the podcasts

Precedents

Sq'ewlets site (Lyons et al. 2016) · cultural mapping (Jeannotte 2016)

MY CONTRIBUTION: NARRATIVE MULTIMODAL ANTHROPOLOGY

PODCASTING AS METHOD

Multimodal anthropology opened the field to media. I bring narrative, kinship and Black fugitivity into multimodal practice, through the podcast, toward the health and well-being of Black communities.

1 Narrative

Begin from a personal, kin connection to racial violence (Wesley Johnson's name at the Memorial).

2 Multimodal

Sound and image recorded on site, sound that is "felt not simply heard."

3 Fugitive

Refusal and reclamation as method, to "preserve and re-imagine narratives that counteract erasure."

4 Return

Oral-telling as return: the episode goes back to the people and the place.

Collins, Durlington & Gill 2017 → Takaragawa et al. 2019 → Campbell 2024, "Deep Roots, Bama Soil" (Museum Anthropology, doi:10.1111/muan.12298)

WHERE WE ARE

The problem

Key terms

The method: the podcast

- **Inception: the Memorial**
- **Three sites**

Oral-telling as return

Where it stands

Inception: National Memorial for Peace and Justice



Site 1: Congo Square



Site 2: McCorkle Place



Site 3: Hotel Lincoln

📍 Inception · Master's thesis project

NATIONAL MEMORIAL FOR PEACE AND JUSTICE

IN MY WORDS:

"...the body as a medium... to discover seemingly insignificant elements that hold deep meaning."

Episode published 2020

Content note: historical newspaper coverage of racial violence.

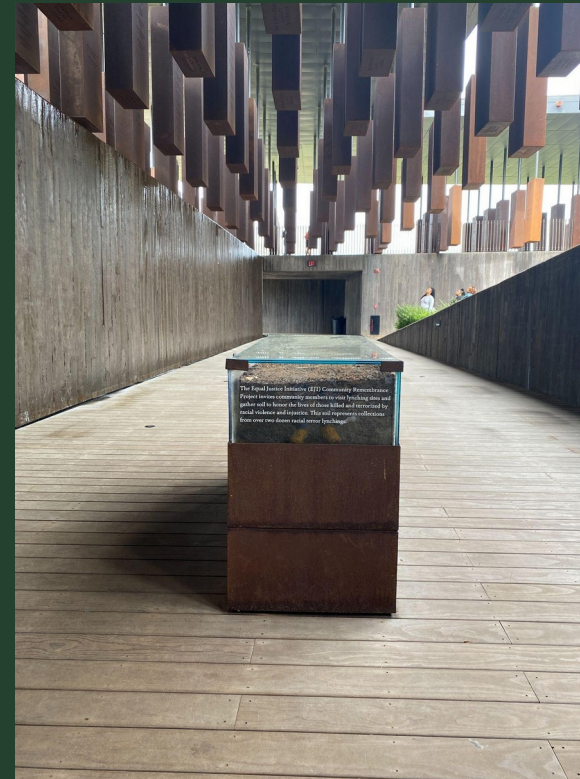
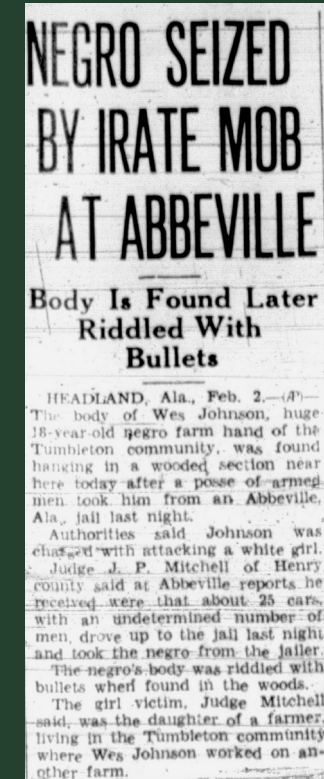
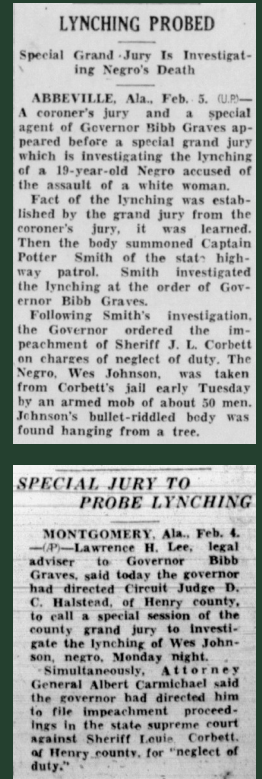


Photo Credit: EJI Remembrance Project & Tylar Campbell



Newspaper Archive clipping from the Anniston Star in 1937. Photo by Tylar Campbell.





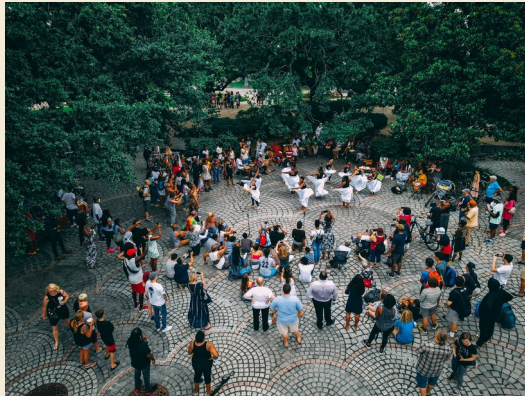
SITE 01 · CONGO SQUARE · NEW ORLEANS, LA

SITE 1 · CULTURAL PRESERVATION

CONGO SQUARE

What I made: rites of passage images and drums.

Drums and Drones pairs traditional African American drumming with drone photos and film of Congo Square, New Orleans.



Episode on final pass

CELL



CONGO SQUARE



Congo Square is in the "vicinity" of a spot which Houmas Indians used before the arrival of the French for celebrating their annual corn harvest and was considered sacred ground. The gathering of enslaved African vendors in Congo Square originated as early as the late 1740's during Louisiana's French colonial period and continued during the Spanish colonial era as one of the city's public markets. By 1803, Congo Square had become famous for the gatherings of enslaved Africans who drummed, danced, sang and traded on Sunday afternoons. By 1819, these gatherings numbered as many as 500 to 600 people. Among the most famous dances were the Bamboula, the Calinda and the Congo. These African cultural expressions gradually developed into Mardi Gras Indian traditions, the Second line and eventually New Orleans jazz and rhythm and blues.

CONGO SQUARE WAS LISTED ON THE NATIONAL REGISTER OF HISTORIC PLACES ON JANUARY 28, 1993.



SITE 02 • MCCORKLE PLACE • CHAPEL HILL, NC

SFU

SITE 2 • HERITAGE PRESERVATION | ORAL / LITERARY

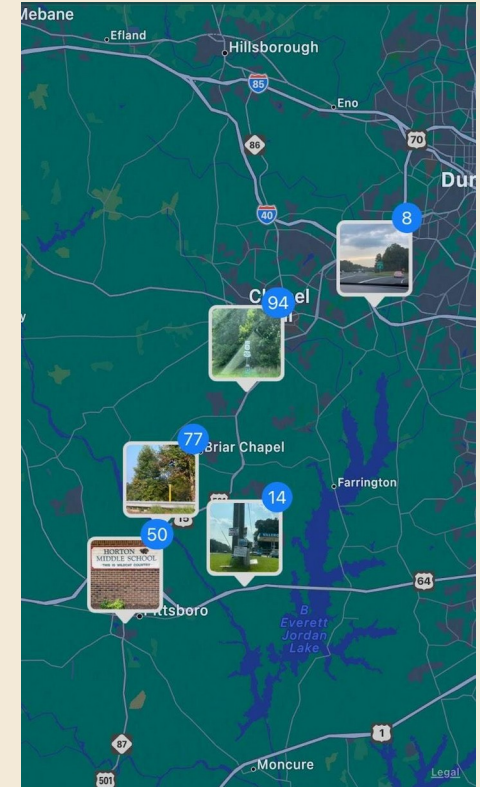
HORTON'S POEMS AS A MAP

“While reading his poetry books, I found literary details about places – the Haw River, and McCorkle Place, where he sold his poetry on campus at UNC Chapel Hill. I went to those places, then created a 360° walkthrough and embedded his poems.”

McCorkle Place • Haw River

What I made: a 360° walkthrough of McCorkle Place, with his poems embedded.

360° walkthrough done • episode to record



Scan to walk McCorkle Place



SITE 03 · HOTEL LINCOLN · SOUTH BATON ROUGE

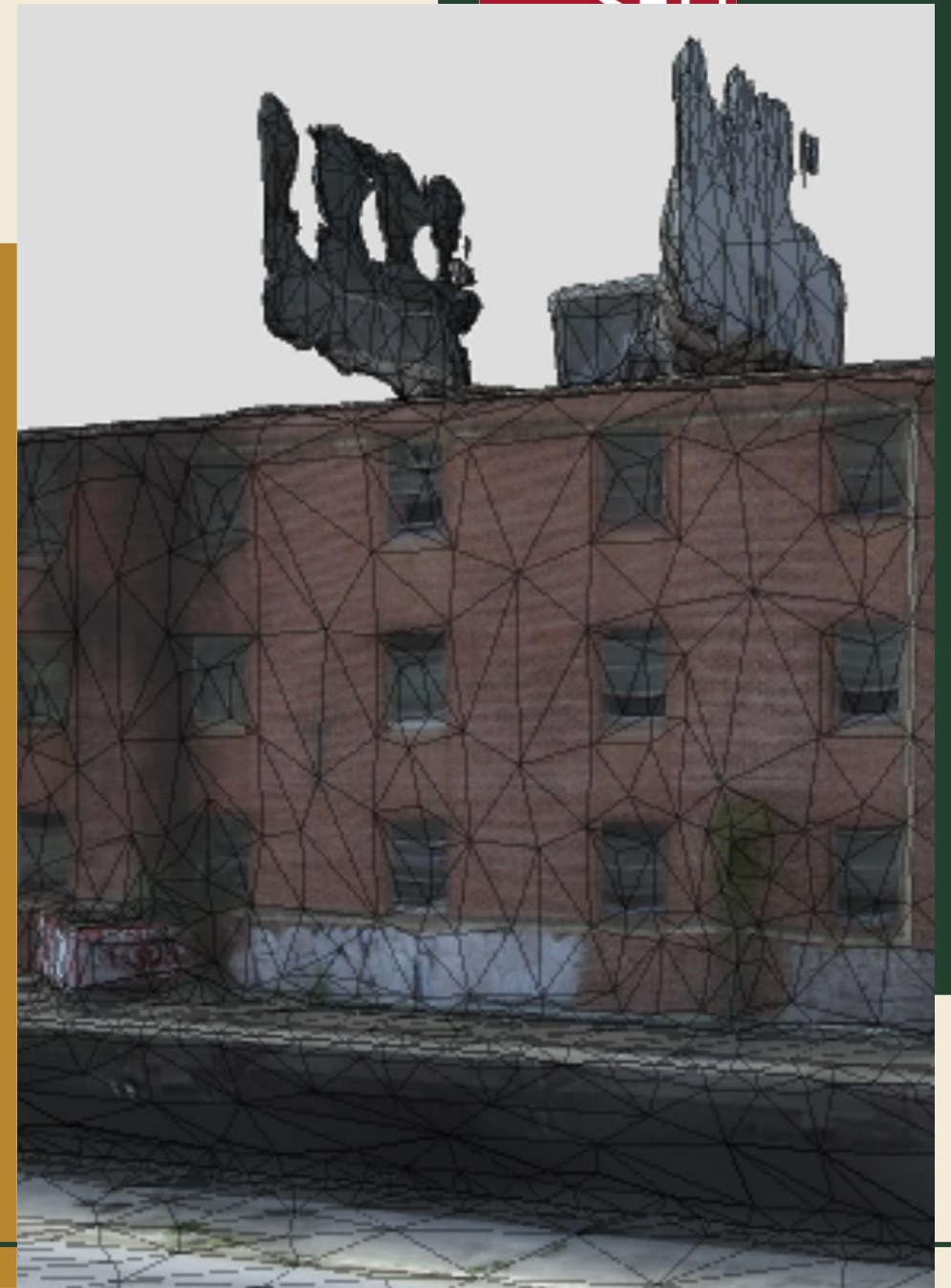
SITE 3 · BUILDING HERITAGE PRESERVATION

HOTEL LINCOLN

What I made: a photogrammetry (3D scan) of the historic hotel.

Next: an interactive website that brings together the 3D models, AR, and audio-visual stories.

Photogrammetry done · episode in edit



ORAL-TELLING AS RETURN

IN MY WORDS:

“Traversing Spaces’ has been what I have theorized as my way forward.”

“...remembrance of family members through storytelling.”

The podcast episodes and the Traversing Spaces website bring each site back to the people it belongs to.



TRACE

A prototype for linking ancestry records back to people and places.

Trace WORKING TITLE Corridors > Chesapeake to Upper Canada, 1840–1870 > Review

Search people, places, records / EXAMPLE DATA RD

Review queue 4 of 23

Kent County Heritage Society (example archive) · assigned to you

All 23 Strong 9 Family 6 Not sure 3

Susan Crane #1
1851 Church register ↔ 1874 Settlement roll
Strong ✓ You · 9:12 AM

Hester Vane #2
1849 Runaway ad ↔ 1852 Church register
Weak ✗ You · 9:20 AM

Isaac Crane #3
1866 'Information wanted' ↔ 1870 Census
Medium ⚠ You · 9:31 AM

Abel Crane #4
1851 Church register ↔ 1874 Settlement roll
Strong Reviewing now

Abel Crane #5
1866 'Information wanted' ↔ 1847 Runaway ad
Medium Family tie

Jacob Mercer #6
1855 Runaway ad ↔ 1861 Census, Canada West
Medium

Lydia Ashby #7
1858 Church register ↔ 1868 Freedmen's Bureau
Weak Not sure x1

Thomas Greer #8
1844 Runaway ad ↔ 1850 Settlement roll
Strong

Sarah Wilkes #9
1862 Church register ↔ 1866 Freedmen's Bureau
Medium

Sorted by match strength · 3 decided today

PROPOSED MATCH · #4 OF 23

Is this the same person? Strong

CHURCH RECORDS · ST. CATHARINES

1851 · Church register entry
St. Catharines, Canada West

Name as written **Abell Craine**
Age stated **about 28** → b. c. 1823
Origin **late of Kent Co., Maryland**
Spouse **Susan**
Occupation not stated
Record ID EX-CR-1851-044 · p. 12

"Received into fellowship: Abell Craine, about 28, late of Kent Co., Maryland, & Susan his wife."

✓ Name spelling variant
Abell Craine ↔ Abel Crane (sound-alike)

✓ Same place of origin, same spouse
Maryland (Kent Co.) · wife Susan in both

YOUR NOTE · SAVED WITH THE DECISION Focus E

Checked the 1861 Canada West census (example): no Abel Crane listed in St. Catharines. A move east before 1861 fits the Halifax roll. Same wife's name is the strongest tie!

Links count only after approval. Your name, time and note are logged with this decision.

NOVA SCOTIA ARCHIVES

1874 · Settlement roll
Africville, Halifax · household listing

Name as written **Abel Crane**
Age stated **aged 50** → b. c. 1824
Origin **native of Maryland**
Spouse **Susan**
Occupation **labourer**
Record ID EX-NSA-1874-212 · line 7

"Abel Crane, labourer, aged 50, native of Maryland. Susan, wife. From Canada West."

✓ Age within 2 years
Born c. 1823 vs. c. 1824

⚠ 23-year gap, no records between
Check 1861 & 1871 census before approving

✗ Reject R

⚠ Not sure N

✓ Approve link A

J K next / previous A approve R reject N not sure E edit note O open scan ? all shortcuts

Abel Crane

b. c. 1823, Kent County, Maryland · 5 records

✓ 3 approved 2 proposed



APPROVED TRAIL who approved, when

- Runaway advertisement** Oct 1847
Chestertown, MD · Freedom on the Move
✓ A. Mensah · 14 Sep 2026
- Church register entry** 1851
St. Catharines, Canada West · Church records
✓ J. Whitfield · 18 Sep 2026
- Freedmen's Bureau register** 1867
Chestertown, MD · FamilySearch index
✓ A. Mensah · 22 Sep 2026
- 'Information wanted' notice** 1866
Philadelphia · Last Seen, Villanova
⚠ Proposed · queue #5
- Settlement roll** 1874
Africville, Halifax · Nova Scotia Archives
⚠ Proposed · comparing now

HISTORY OF THIS LINK

- 2 Oct **Trace matcher** proposed the link (4 of 5 signals)
 - 3 Oct **J. Whitfield** marked Not sure: "check 1861 census first"
- Today **You** are reviewing · 9:34 AM PT

9:41

< People EXAMPLE DATA

Abel Crane
b. c. 1823, Kent County, Maryland · 3 family ties

Trail Family Places

Isaac Crane
brother? · fl. 1866

Abel Crane
b. c. 1823

Susan Crane
wife · m. by 1851

Hannah Crane
daughter · bap. 1853

Approved tie
Proposed tie

1851 register
1853 baptism

EACH TIE CITES ITS RECORD approved by

Susan Crane wife
"...Abell Craine, late of Kent Co., & Susan his wife."
1851 church register · St. Catharines
✓ J. Whitfield

Hannah Crane daughter
"Hannah, daughter of Abel & Susan Crane, baptized."
1853 baptism · St. Catharines
✓ A. Mensah

Isaac Crane brother?
"...of my brother Abel, who left Kent County in 1847."
1866 notice · Last Seen
⚠ Proposed

Search Map People Review 23

Prototype · all names and records shown are fictional example data

WHERE IT STANDS



THANK YOU



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traversnspaces.com

PHOTOS: TYLAR CAMPBELL; EJI REMEMBRANCE PROJECT.

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